Swedish Defence University

How to legitimize a war

A Critical Discourse Analysis of Benjamin Netanyahu's legitimization strategies on the war in Gaza since October 7, 2023

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Abstract

This study examines how legitimacy is constructed and defended through political discourse over time in relation to international criticism during an armed conflict. While previous research has often treated legitimization as relatively static and established at the outset of a conflict, this thesis approaches legitimacy as a dynamic, ongoing process. The study focuses on political speeches delivered by Israel's Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu between 2023 and 2025 in relation to international criticism of the war in Gaza following the events of October 7, 2023. The relevance to War Studies lies in understanding the role of discourse as a key mechanism through which political actors seek to maintain support for military action and political authority during armed conflicts. A qualitative case study design is employed, applying a Critical Discourse Analysis approach. Drawing on Antonio Reyes' framework of legitimization strategies and Teun van Dijk's socio-cognitive theory of context, the analysis examines how legitimization strategies are employed at the linguistic level and how they relate to the political and international context in which they are situated. The findings suggest that legitimization strategies are employed flexibly and evolve in relation to changing political and international circumstances.

Keywords: Critical Discourse Analysis, legitimization strategies, political speech, Israel, Palestine, Hamas, context, discourse

List of abbreviations:

CDA – Critical Discourse Analysis

COI – The Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory, including East Jerusalem, and Israel

DHA – Discourse Historical Approach

ICC – International Criminal Court

IDF – Israeli Defense Forces

IHL – International Humanitarian Law

IHRL – International Human Rights Law

LOAC – Law of Armed Conflict

PLO – Palestinian Liberation Organization

SFL – Systemic Functional Linguistics

UN – United Nations

US – United States

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1. Introduction

1.1 Research problem

In contemporary armed conflicts, the legitimization of war has become increasingly complex and contested. Political actors construct narratives that combine legal justifications with emotional appeals, moral evaluations and historical grievances to justify the use of force. Claims of defending democracy, human rights or sovereignty are frequently employed by states in pursuit of aggressive goals, blurring the distinction between defensive and offensive warfare (Yendell & Hidalgo, 2025:2).

While existing research provides valuable insights into the moral and political legitimization of war, much of the literature conceptualizes legitimacy as relatively static and primarily examines it at the beginning of a conflict. This risks overlooking how legitimacy is continuously recalibrated as conflicts unfold and how political actors respond to increasing civilian casualties, shifting alliances and changing media narratives. A recent scholar notes that legitimacy may change over time in response to such pressures, emphasizing the need to treat legitimization as a dynamic, context-dependent process rather than a static event (Alexandrescu, 2025:2).

This thesis addresses this gap by examining how legitimacy is constructed, defended and recalibrated through political discourse over the course of an armed conflict, and how these shifts can be understood in relation to international political and legal criticism. By focusing on discourse as a critical component in constructing legitimacy, the study moves beyond static analyses of war justification and contributes to understanding how political actors employ legitimization discourse to sustain armed conflicts, facing international criticism.

In relation to War Studies, this thesis contributes by examining how political discourse functions as a strategic tool in armed conflicts, justifying the methods and means of warfare to secure continued support for military operations and to mitigate international and public scrutiny. The importance lies in understanding how political actors actively revise their justifications in relation to changing environmental conditions and how this influences perceptions of a conflict (Alexandrescu, 2025:1-4). Examining how political leaders construct and adjust legitimization discourse during armed conflict may also be beneficial since

legitimacy constitutes a key form of power and authority, enabling the continuation of military action through consent rather than coercion (Amossy, 2022:15).

1.2 Aim and research question

This thesis aims to examine how legitimacy is constructed and defended through political discourse over time in relation to international criticism during an armed conflict. The study conducts a case study of Israel's Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's political discourse between 2023 and 2025 on the war in Gaza following the events of October 7, 2023.

By analyzing Netanyahu's political speeches, the thesis examines how legitimization strategies are employed over time and how they relate to the political and international context in which they are situated. The study adopts a critical discourse approach, drawing on Antonio Reyes' framework of legitimization strategies (2011) and Teun van Dijk's socio-cognitive theory of context (2008) to analyze the relationship between discourse and context.

The study seeks to answer the following research question:

- How is legitimacy constructed and defended in Benjamin Netanyahu's political discourse between 2023 and 2025 in relation to international criticism during the war in Gaza?

This is examined by answering two operationalized questions:

- What legitimization strategies does Netanyahu employ in his speeches to justify the war in Gaza?

- Do these strategies remain consistent or vary over time, and how can any observed variation be interpreted in relation to the political and international context?

1.3 Structure

The first chapter introduces the research topic, outlines the research problem, and presents the thesis's aim and research question. The second chapter provides a brief historical background on the Israel-Palestine conflict, leading up to current events. The third chapter reviews the relevant literature and situates the thesis within the existing research. The fourth chapter presents the analytical framework and key concepts guiding the analysis. The fifth chapter outlines the methodology and empirical material. The sixth chapter analyzes Benjamin Netanyahu’s political discourse and presents a discussion of the findings. The final chapter presents the study’s conclusion and concludes this thesis.

2. Background

The Israeli-Palestinian conflict is complex and multifaceted, involving religious, political and societal dimensions. The historical background presented in this thesis is therefore limited, but it aims to provide the historical context necessary for understanding the analysis.

2.1 The Israel-Palestine conflict 1917-2023

The roots of the Israel-Palestine conflict trace back to the aftermath of the First World War, when the League of Nations placed Palestine under British administrative control in 1922. The British administration supported the Balfour Declaration of 1917, which called for "the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people" (Gelvin, 2007:88). In the following years, large-scale Jewish immigration to the area contributed to increased tensions with the Arab population in Palestine, culminating in the Arab revolt in 1936, demanding independence. The revolt ultimately failed, despite British attempts to resolve the unrest and discord in Palestine (Harms & Ferry, 2021:78-80).

In 1947, Britain referred the issue to the United Nations, which proposed partitioning Palestine into two independent states, one Arab and one Jewish. In 1948, the state of Israel declared independence and as war broke out, the United Nations took a passive stance (Harms & Ferry, 2021:89-93). The following years were marked by Israeli expansion into Palestinian territory and the displacement of more than half of the Palestinian population. In response, the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) was founded in 1964 and later recognized as the legitimate representative of the Palestinian people. The PLO aimed to reconstruct Palestinian national identity and to secure support from Arab states and the international community for the Palestinian cause (Sela, 2014:270-278).

During the First Intifada in 1987, a widespread Palestinian uprising against Israeli occupation in Gaza and the West Bank, the Islamic Resistance Movement (Hamas) emerged as a political branch of the Muslim Brotherhood in Gaza. Hamas refused to recognize the state of Israel and sought jihad for the liberation of Palestine (Wolf & Berger Hobson, 2025:3). Following Israel's withdrawal from Gaza in 2005, Hamas won a majority in the 2006 Palestinian legislative elections and has controlled the territory since, without new elections. Supported by Iran, the

group has carried out terror attacks and suicide operations against military and civilian targets in Israel. Hamas is designated as a foreign terrorist group by the EU, the UN, the U.S. and Israel (Brenner, 2017:x-11).

Throughout the 21st century, the Israel-Palestine conflict has been characterized by cycles of violence and failed peace processes. A second intifada against Israeli occupation started in the West Bank in 2000, after which Israel constructed a barrier wall around the area (Harms & Ferry, 2021:170-174). Major military confrontations between Hamas and Israel have occurred in 2008, 2014 and most recently in 2023. The latest one resulting in an extreme humanitarian crisis with Palestinians facing a blockade and being denied water, food and medicine (Kumar et al. 2025:13,128).

2.2 The Israel-Hamas war after October 7, 2023

The Palestinian territories – including Gaza, the West Bank and East Jerusalem – have been under Israeli occupation since 1967 (Kumar et al. 2025:92). On October 7, 2023, members of Hamas' armed wing, alongside Palestinian militants, carried out large-scale coordinated rocket attacks on Israeli civilian communities and military bases near the Gaza border. According to Israeli sources, these attacks resulted in at least 1,200 deaths and 252 hostages taken to Gaza. The attackers employed mortar fire, rockets and drones to target specific towns and villages as well, and in some cases entered areas on foot (United Nations, 2024a:6-7). The Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory, including East Jerusalem, and Israel (COI) concluded that serious violations of human rights law (IHRL) and international humanitarian law (IHL), as well as war crimes were committed by the attackers on the October 7, including torture, kidnappings, murder, intentional attacks on civilians and sexual violence (United Nations, 2024a:55-59).

In response, Netanyahu declared war on Hamas in Gaza on October 8 and launched a large-scale military campaign in Gaza in pursuit of two objectives: the complete destruction of Hamas and the rescue of Israeli hostages (Bordas, 2024:11). The campaign has been significantly larger in scale in terms of injuries and casualties than any previous operation since 2006. On October 9, Israel imposed a complete siege on Gaza, cutting off access to essential resources and humanitarian aid, including water and food (United Nations, 2024b:5-6). COI reported that Israel was employing collective punishment against the Palestinian population in Gaza and

intentionally using starvation as a method of warfare. In June 2024, COI further documented that the Israeli Defense Forces (IDF) targeted densely populated civilian areas and destroyed civilian infrastructure in Gaza. The Commission noted that in many cases, it found no verifiable evidence that the attacked objects were legitimate military targets. The report concluded that the scale of civilian casualties and destruction appears disproportionate to the anticipated military advantage and that the methods used – including the use of wide-area explosives in densely populated environments – failed to comply with principles of distinction and precaution under IHL (United Nations, 2024b:107-113).

By October 19, 2025, the World Health Organization (2025) reported 68,216 fatalities and 170,361 injuries in Gaza since October 7, 2023. Israeli political and military officials have consistently justified the military operations in Gaza in two ways: the right of self-defense for the attack on Israeli citizens and the right of self-defense in preventing another holocaust, asserting that the October 7 attacks posed an existential threat to the state of Israel, thereby justifying the large-scale military response to prevent future ones (Bordas, 2024:3).

2.3 International criticism of Israel

On May 20, 2024, the ICC Prosecutor Karim Khan and his office filed an application for an arrest warrant against Netanyahu. Khan presented reasonable grounds for believing that Netanyahu and his Minister of Defence, Yoav Gallant, bear criminal responsibility for several war crimes and crimes against humanity in Gaza (Khan, 2024). On November 21, 2024, six months later, the ICC issued an arrest warrant for Netanyahu for war crimes and crimes against humanity. The charges include war crimes of starvation as a method of warfare and of intentionally directing attacks against the civilian population. For crimes against humanity, the charges were murder, inhumane acts and persecution from October 8, 2023, until at least May 20, 2024 (International Criminal Court, 2024).

On September 16, 2025, the COI concluded that the state of Israel bears responsibility for the failure to prevent genocide, the commission of genocide and the failure to punish genocide against the Palestinian people in Gaza since October 2023. Genocide is defined in Article 2 of the Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide (1948) as "…any of the following acts committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnic,

racial or religious group, as such: killing members of the group; causing serious bodily or mental harm to members of the group; deliberately inflicting on the group conditions of life calculated to bring about its physical destruction in whole or in part; imposing measures intended to prevent births within the group; forcibly transferring children of the group to another group". Genocide is thereby committed when one or more of these acts are committed with intent, and the COI determined that Israeli authorities and security forces have committed four out of five possible acts. The COI also noted that this was preceded by decades of unlawful Israeli occupation of Palestinian territories, calling for the removal of the Palestinian population from their lands (United Nations, 2025:71).

3. Previous research

This chapter presents previous research and contributions on legitimization strategies in discourse and analyses of political speeches by Benjamin Netanyahu. Previous research has focused primarily on individual speeches at specific events, whereas this thesis examines discursive strategies employed over time. The literature review provides a theoretical foundation and positions the thesis within the current state of the art of War Studies.

3.1 Critical discourse analysis of Benjamin Netanyahu's speeches

Several scholars have analyzed Benjamin Netanyahu's political speeches using CDA, examining different contexts and discursive strategies to understand how power and support are constructed in discourse. The previous research below analyzes different speeches by Netanyahu to illustrate different discursive strategies and contexts, and how they may differ.

Abu Khaled (2020) conducts a critical discourse analysis of Netanyahu's 2014 UN General Assembly speech on the Israel-Hamas conflict, using Wodak's (2009) discourse-historical approach (DHA) and van Leeuwen's (2008) taxonomy of social actor representation. She aims to expose how Netanyahu employs language to manipulate power relations, distort facts to justify crimes and frame the war as legitimate. Her analysis focuses on how Netanyahu constructs an in-group (Israel) and an out-group (Hamas), through positive self-presentation and negative other-presentation. Abu Khaled finds that Netanyahu, through the discursive strategy of predication, consistently frames Israel as a victim acting in self-defense, while shifting responsibility for violence onto Hamas. Israeli suffering caused by the Palestinians is emphasized, while Israeli violence and responsibility are mitigated. Discursive strategies are used to relate to the audience and portray Hamas as an enemy not only to Israel, but to the international community as a whole, reinforcing the moral justification and necessity for Israel's military actions (Abu Khaled, 2020:40).

Building on a similar theoretical framework to Abu Khaled, Algurjia et al. (2024) also apply Wodak's discourse-historical approach, together with van Leeuwen's social actor framework, to analyze Netanyahu's 2024 speech to the United States Congress. While they also identify positive self-presentation and negative other-presentation, their analysis focuses on persuasion

techniques to manufacture audience consent and approval (Algurjia et al., 2024:2807-2808). They find that Netanyahu relies heavily on emotional and psychological appeals, particularly when his claims lack factual evidence, to gain approval from both the American and international audiences. References to historical events such as the Holocaust and contemporary U.S security threats such as Iran, function to evoke feelings of sympathy, fear and a sense of collective duty and moral urgency. These strategies are consistently used throughout the speech to legitimize Israeli military operations against the Palestinians (Algurjia et al., 2024:2817). Extending on Abu Khaled's work, Algurjia et al. highlight how emotions in rhetoric, rather than facts, are central to Netanyahu's efforts to gain support.

Arifiyah et al. (2024) conduct a critical discourse analysis of Benjamin Netanyahu's speech in response to the ICC arrest warrant issued against Israeli leaders. The study applies Fairclough's three-dimensional model and theory of power (1992) to examine how Netanyahu uses political discourse to shape public perception of the warrant and how power and language are adopted to legitimize Israel's military actions. Their research builds on the studies by Abu Khaled and Algurjia et al., by further exploring how Netanyahu constructs and maintains political power and how political context influences his discourse (Arifiyah et al., 2024:240-241). Unlike the previous studies, their chosen framework allows for a detailed analysis of linguistic strategies across micro- (textual), meso- (discursive), and macro-levels (sociopolitical). The authors conclude that Netanyahu employs multiple discursive strategies to discredit the ICC, justify Israel's self-defense and create a moral opposition between Israel and Hamas to influence both public and international opinion (Arifiyah et al., 2024:245-246).

Kieu and Tran (2025) and Alsemeiri et al. (2024) both examine Benjamin Netanyahu's 2024 UN General Debate speech using CDA, though with different objectives and methodological approaches. Kieu and Tran aim to uncover linguistic strategies, underlying ideology and how these shape audience perceptions (2025:1). To do so, they first apply a quantitative method using AntConc to identify and categorize grammatical structures, followed by Fairclough's first dimension of textual analysis in his three-dimensional model to examine vocabulary and grammar (2025:9). While Alsemeiri et al. share a similar interest in how discourse constructs ideological meanings and sociopolitical realities, they observe a research gap in how leaders maintain legitimacy while facing multiple challenges. To address this gap, they extend their focus to how political discourse, even when confronted with criticism, retains its impact and influence (2024:5-10). Their analysis is grounded in van Dijk's socio-cognitive framework,

with particular focus on how lexicalization and metaphors contribute to narratives of legitimacy and moral superiority (2024:2).

Kieu and Tran conclude by identifying two lexical devices: repetition and metaphors, and two grammatical features: the we-you pronoun and active and passive voice. Along with three ideologies: refuting international criticism, mobilizing international support and advancing Israel's vision of peace. They also present how Netanyahu's speech is positioned and functions on a situational, institutional and societal level (2025:17). While their work focuses on identifying textual features, Alsemeiri et al. offer a deeper analysis of how such features function in practice. They show that Netanyahu's use of lexical choices, binary oppositions and metaphors enables him to maintain legitimacy and support, despite documented violations of international law. For example, they highlight his reliance on the us vs. them dichotomy and his alignment of Israel with universal values such as peace, drawing parallels to van Leeuwen's mythopoesis (2024:15-17). Together, their studies contribute methodologically, theoretically and empirically to this thesis by demonstrating the varied applicability of CDA to Netanyahu's 2024 speech and by illustrating how different analytical approaches can identify and explain the discursive strategies employed in his political discourse.

3.2 Thesis position

This thesis positions itself within the state of the art by addressing a gap in existing research concerning legitimization discourse over time. While previous research provides in-depth analyses of Netanyahu's political discourse, focusing on legitimization, persuasion and perception, they primarily examine individual speeches situated in specific contexts. As a result, existing research offers limited insight into how legitimization strategies may shift in emphasis of function as an armed conflict evolves and international criticism intensifies. Building on prior research on discursive strategies, this thesis extends the literature by examining how these strategies are employed over time.

4. Analytical framework

This chapter presents the theoretical framework developed by Antonio Reyes and Teun van Dijk, which will be applied to the speeches to analyze the discourse. The chapter also addresses important concepts relevant to a better understanding of the study.

4.1 Antonio Reyes legitimization strategies

Antonio Reyes presents a theoretical framework on legitimization strategies in conflicts. His research builds on van Leeuwen's work on four categories of legitimization in discourse (1996, 2007, 2008). Both scholars agree that language functions as a tool of social control, reflecting underlying power dynamics, but Reyes advances the discussion by demonstrating how legitimization strategies are employed to justify military action and maintain public approval. Reyes' framework is considered to work both as a model that provides a systematic categorization of legitimization strategies and as a theoretical lens that shows how these strategies are constructed through language. It is considered an appropriate supplement to CDA, as it takes a critical approach to discourse and provides insights into how language is an instrument of control and power (Reyes, 2011:781).

Reyes argues that legitimization deserves special attention, as it is through speech that political leaders justify their agendas, shape courses of action and maintain their hegemonic power. He defines legitimization as a justification of social behavior, enacted through argumentation to explain social actions and ideas. The act is related to a goal, often seeking the audience's approval and support, and can be motivated by desires to maintain power, improve relationships or achieve social acceptance (Reyes, 2011:783).

Reyes' theoretical framework offers a categorization of five discursive legitimization strategies: legitimization through emotions, a hypothetical future, rationality, voices of expertise and altruism.

1. Legitimization through emotions

Emotions are part of our shared cognitive understanding of social behavior, in which specific feelings are often associated with particular actions or situations. However, powerful emotions such as anger, fear and sadness may have the power to distort that understanding and shape how reality is perceived. This means that the speaker, by intentionally evoking certain feelings, may guide audiences to interpret events in a desired way and to accept their proposals. Fear is arguably the most effective emotion to trigger and is often constructed through linguistic choices to create a negative "them-group" of the social actors and a positive "us-group" of the speaker and audience (Reyes, 2011:788-792).

2. Legitimization through a hypothetical future

In this strategy, the speaker will often utilize a time frame connecting the past, present and future to justify a course of action. Drawing on prior experiences, the speaker portrays a potential negative future scenario and argues that their actions are justified and necessary to prevent it. The audience is left with two choices: take action according to the speaker, and all will be fine, or take no action, and the past will repeat itself. Linguistically, this is often constructed through linguistic structures and choices such as "'If + past [protasis] → would + Infinitive without to [apodosis]', or 'If + present [protasis] → will + Infinitive without to [apodosis]'" (Reyes, 2011:793-795).

3. Legitimization through rationality

This strategy portrays action as deliberate and carefully considered, allowing the speaker to present their choice as rational and the outcome of thoughtful evaluation. Reyes positions rationality as a social construct, representing the actions deemed "right" and "make sense" within a given social group, often grounded in its morals and values. One example often referred to in political discourse is the notion that the speaker did not start the conflict and is simply responding to it as necessary (Reyes, 2011:798).

4. Legitimization through voices of expertise

This strategy works by bringing expert or authoritative voices into the speech to support the speaker's position. Political speakers already possess institutional authority through their positions and platforms, which grants them status and enables them to present their views as truth. By citing experts, speakers can further justify their actions by demonstrating that their claims are supported by knowledgeable and reliable authorities, thereby enhancing their credibility. Linguistically, this refers to actors who, for example, "say", "announce" or "report" something that supports the speaker's argument (Reyes, 2011:800-801).

5. Legitimization through altruism

The final strategy concerns the speaker presenting their actions as beneficial to others. The action taken is portrayed as necessary to safeguard and serve other communities, rather than as solely driven by personal interests. In political discourse, this often refers to protecting Western values such as freedom, democracy and equality. No specific linguistic observation is provided (Reyes, 2011, 801-803).

These legitimization strategies are presented in an Excel file here, and coded as follows: Emotions (Em), hypothetical future (Fu), rationality (Ra), voices of expertise (Ex) and altruism (Al) when observed and perceived in the speeches after Reyes characteristics provided. This abbreviation is followed by a number to facilitate coding and to provide relevant information and interpretations of the excerpts. As Reyes presents five categories, this study is limited to those five and does not account for other legitimization strategies used by Netanyahu. Consequently, the study risks overlooking forms of discursive strategies that fall outside Reyes' scope. However, because Reyes' framework is specific to discourse in conflict, it is highly relevant to this thesis, enabling the author to systematically identify and categorize the legitimization strategies used by Netanyahu to justify the war in Gaza.

4.2 Teun van Dijk's socio-cognitive theory of context

This study draws on Teun van Dijk's critical approach to context models, which explain how social situations influence language use and discourse. According to van Dijk, context models

are a type of mental model, namely the speaker's subjective mental representation of the current communicative situation. They are subjective and dynamic, reflecting the speaker's personal interpretation of the situation as well as shared sociocultural knowledge about social roles, norms and expectations (van Dijk, 2009:6-7). These models guide speakers in structuring and adapting their discourse, helping them assess what is appropriate and relevant in a given situation (van Dijk, 2009:17-18).

Context models account for both social and personal variation in discourse, including style and lexical choices. They serve as a link between society, situation, interaction and communication, illustrating how speakers strategically present beliefs and knowledge depending on the situation. Although important, van Dijk emphasizes that establishing a causal relationship between context and discourse structures is both theoretically and empirically impossible. Instead, context models provide a framework for evaluating communicative appropriateness and how a speaker adapts to the environment through their subjective interpretation of the social and political context (van Dijk, 2008:219-221).

van Dijk proposes that context models are organized by cognitive frameworks, which help speakers analyze and understand communicative situations. Key categories include: setting (time, place and physical or social circumstances), participants (roles, relationships and social identities), activities (what happens in the situation) and mental properties of participants (knowledge, beliefs, goals and intentions). By considering these categories, speakers can continuously interpret situations and adapt their discourse to the most relevant and socially appropriate properties (van Dijk, 2009:249-252).

van Dijk's theory of context is employed in this thesis as an interpretive framework to examine potential adaptations in Netanyahu's legitimization strategies between 2023 and 2025, and to understand how these adaptations may relate to changes in the surrounding political and international context. Drawing on van Dijk's concept of context models, the analysis examines how discourse may be shaped by the speaker's subjective interpretation of relevant contextual factors, particularly international criticism directed at Netanyahu and Israel, such as the ICC and the UN. This approach has several limitations. First, the analysis focuses on selected aspects of the international context, while other contextual factors that may also influence Netanyahu's discourse fall outside the scope of this study. Second, because context models are inherently subjective, the analysis relies on this author's interpretations, which entails a risk of

overinterpretation. Despite these limitations, the framework is valuable as it offers a lens for understanding how discourse may be shaped by perceived contextual pressures and expectations.

4.3 Concepts

4.3.1 Power

As political actors seek to maintain their hegemonic power, discourse becomes a valuable tool for that purpose. Political actors can draw on the power of their position and status to explain and justify actions in ways that secure public support. This means that the authority and legitimacy of political discourse stem not only from its content but also from the institutional setting in which it is delivered and the official status of the speaker. Together, these factors provide the message with credibility and power (Reyes, 2011:783-784). Grounded in their institutional and social roles, political actors can, through discourse, implicitly claim the authority to define what is right and justified. By inhabiting a position of power and enacting legitimizing speech, they position the audience as recipients of that authority and encourage acceptance of their justifications simply because they stem from an authorized and institutionalized position of power (Cap, 2008:22). Discourse as a political practice establishes, sustains and challenges power relations. Power is exercised through discourse, as well as contested within the discourse (Fairclough, 1992:67).

In relation to this thesis, the concept of political and institutional power is essential for understanding how Netanyahu, as a political actor, draws on his position of power to construct credibility and legitimacy for Israel's military actions in Gaza. It also highlights the power relationship between Israel and the United States (U.S.), as Netanyahu's ability to attend the General Debate in 2025, after the ICC arrest warrant, was made possible by U.S. cooperation and the U.S. not being a party to the ICC Rome Statute, which exempts it from the court's jurisdiction (ICC, 1998).

4.3.2 Legitimization

Legitimacy is considered a crucial aspect of power dynamics, allowing power to be exercised through voluntary compliance rather than coercion. It can, in a sense, be understood as the speaker being given acceptance of authority by different social groups (McCullough 2015:7).

Legitimization can be understood as an act of defending oneself, in which the speaker must provide good reasons, grounds, or acceptable motivations for past or present actions in response to actual or anticipated criticism. In institutional contexts, legitimization is a discourse that justifies official actions by referring to the political, social or legal rights and duties associated with the particular role or position of the speaker. By legitimizing behavior, institutional actors may present themselves as acting in accordance with established norms and upholding dominant moral orders. Even political actors with absolute power regularly legitimize actions to preserve their public image and reputation. In political contexts, legitimization discourse is expected when officials are accused of violating the law or when they anticipate opposition to their political actions. When the legitimacy of a state or official is at stake, legitimization discourse becomes imperative and part of strategic crisis management (van Dijk, 1998:255-257). Legitimization is usually observed by the self, such as positive self-presentation, self-explanation and self-justification, while delegitimization is observed in negative other-presentation, marginalizing and attacking the moral and rationality of the opponent (Chilton, 2004:47).

In armed conflicts, legitimization becomes particularly complex, as aggressors construct narratives blending legal justifications with emotional, historical and ethical appeals. They often refer to defending human rights, democracy and sovereignty and adjusting their narratives as the conflict unfolds (Yendell & Hidalgo, 2025:2-3). Hence, an initially rational justification for war may become untenable as the conflict evolves, necessitating revision to preserve support and mitigate criticism. This process can be seen as iterative discourse: a cycle of adaptation in which political actors continuously revise their arguments in response to public opinion and international criticism (Alexandrescu, 2025:4;17). Ultimately, the act of legitimization is related to a desired goal, which usually seeks to gain the audience's acceptance and support (Reyes, 2011:782).

4.3.3 International support and approval

Why is it important for a state to legitimize its actions in armed conflicts and why does international support and approval matter? Previous research demonstrates a strong connection between popular support for a military campaign and the ability to conduct that campaign successfully. Legitimization therefore plays a crucial role in mobilizing and sustaining such support. In armed conflicts, legitimization serves to uphold moral and legal authority, persuade audiences of the righteousness of military actions and demonstrate compliance with established norms and the law of armed conflict (LOAC). When a state's actions are perceived as illegitimate, the support may be undermined (Ayres & Thurnher, 2019:2-3). In armed conflicts, perceptions of legitimacy enhance the credibility of the strategic goals and the military action intended to achieve them. Thus, adhering to legal and ethical standards is essential for maintaining legitimacy (Corn & Spencer, 2025). In liberal democracies, where public opinion plays a crucial role, legitimacy is particularly important to portray a just cause and garner support for military action (Yendell & Hidalgo, 2025:2).

Within the international community, international law is created by the states themselves. It primarily takes shape through treaties that impose binding obligations and customary rules upon their signatories. States generally comply with these norms to avoid economic, political and social sanctions from other states. When a state violates such norms and its actions as perceived as illegitimate, its credibility decreases and it may potentially lead to isolation from international cooperation. In such circumstances, a crisis of legitimacy arises, as declining support from other states threatens the state's ability to maintain its power. To address this matter, legitimacy needs to be recalibrated by adapting political discourse to reconcile their actions and identities with prevailing international norms and expectations. When a state acts illegitimately, political discourse becomes a strategic tool, used to legitimize actions through rhetorical manipulation (Rotaru, 2016:29-31).

4.3.4 Context

Context can be defined as "the structured set of all properties of a social situation that are possibly relevant for the production, structures, interpretation and functions of text and talk" (van Dijk, 1998:211). In this sense, the physical setting, institutional setting and the power positions of the participants shape how discourse is produced and interpreted. Social situations

reproduce power dynamics, group identities, norms and dominant relations within discourse, while speakers and audiences continually update their understanding as circumstances evolve (van Dijk, 1998:211-213). These contexts ultimately define what appropriate and relevant discourse is (van Dijk, 2006:171) and thus political discourse is best studied in relation to its communicative settings and political function (Schäffner, 1997:4).

Within political discourse, institutional settings and contexts confer power and authority on political actors. The contextual authority enables the political actors to present their interpretations of events as credible and justified. As a result, the institutional power reinforces the perceived truthfulness of the discourse and strengthens the justification of the actions taken (Reyes, 2011:783). Considering context allows the analysis to better account for how Netanyahu's position as political leader, the physical setting of the communicative events, the timing of those events and his subjective interpretation of those events may influence his discourse (van Dijk, 2009:64-65).

5. Methodology and material

This chapter outlines the study's methodological framework and empirical material. It begins with the presentation of the research tradition guiding the study, followed by the method employed and the operationalization of the analysis. The chapter then discusses the thesis's limitations and ethical considerations. Finally, it presents the empirical material and a critical approach to the sources.

5.1 Methodology and method

This study adopts an interpretivist research approach, meaning to "understand what a thing "is" by learning what it does, how particular people use it, in particular contexts" (Schwartz-Shea & Yanow, 2012:23). Interpretivism is suitable for analyzing political discourse, as it views humans as active agents who construct meaning within specific social and political contexts. This meaning is created through language and can be interpreted in multiple ways. Ontologically, this explains why we focus on how humans use language to construct their realities and epistemologically, it illustrates how they use language to make sense of those realities (Schwartz-Shea & Yanow, 2012:46).

The study employs Critical Discourse Analysis, an analytical perspective that examines how power and inequality are enacted, reproduced and legitimized through text and spoken language in social and political contexts. CDA is not a method but a critical approach that can be applied to analyze discourse to expose power dynamics and social injustice (van Dijk, 2015:466). Highly relevant to this study, CDA assumes that language is a key mechanism in maintaining and legitimizing inequality, injustice and oppression (Wodak, 2001:xx). Since language operates on the micro-level analysis and power on the macro-level, CDA helps bridge the gap between these levels by showing how linguistic choices may contribute to broader sociopolitical processes (van Dijk 2015:468-470). CDA emphasizes the importance of linguistic categories such as argumentation but does not provide a fixed set of analytical tools. Instead, researchers must select tools that suit their research question (Wodak & Meyer, 2009:28). Since legitimization is produced through argumentation, by offering reasons that justify social actions and policies, the analysis will focus on identifying these justifications in the speeches (Reyes, 2011:728).

The study combines CDA with a qualitative textual analysis of the transcribed speeches. Textual analysis involves careful reading, to critically examine and deconstruct language to uncover underlying and hidden meanings, structures and intentions. It aligns well with CDA, as it requires the researcher to analyze and interpret the text in its context and in relation to larger sociopolitical frameworks (Hawkins, 2017:1754-1756). This method will allow the author to examine Netanyahu's language and lexical choices, and in combination with CDA, interpret how these choices function to legitimize his actions within broader political contexts.

To answer the first operationalized question, textual analysis is used to examine lexical choices and identify legitimization strategies, which are categorized according to Reyes' five categories of emotions, a hypothetical future, rationality, voices of expertise and altruism. Reyes' defining characteristics for each category will guide the coding and interpretation of the material. For transparency, the categorization process and samples will be presented in an appendix. To answer the second operationalized question, the study compares the speeches to assess whether the legitimization strategies differ between 2023 and 2025. These findings are then analyzed through van Dijk's socio-cognitive theory of context to interpret how the discourse relates to international criticism and scrutiny.

An analysis of political discourse is most successful when it connects linguistic behavior to political behavior, linking micro-level language choices to macro-level political objectives through strategic functions such as legitimization. The thesis begins at the linguistic micro-level, examining lexical and discursive choices. When interpreting the strategic function of these choices, the study operates at an intermediate analytical level. Finally, the analysis situates these strategies within the macro-level political and international context (Schäffner, 1997:2).

5.2 Limitations

Despite its strengths, the methodology entails certain limitations. Textual analysis is dependent on the researcher's own interpretations, experiences and knowledge. Two researchers may read the same text but interpret it differently, highlighting the importance of transparency for maintaining reliability. Additionally, since textual analysis requires extensive reading, there is a risk that data and meanings might be overlooked (Esaiasson et al. 2017:226-228). In this

study, while Reyes provides categorization criteria, the coding and interpretation ultimately rely on the author's judgment. CDA has also been criticized for being overly researcher-focused, lacking analytical coherence, applying unsystematic methods and mixing incompatible concepts. Consequently, the approach risks becoming too broad and making ambitious claims about society (Breeze, 2011:498-500). These critiques do not invalidate the study but highlight the importance of methodological transparency. Since the purpose of the thesis is to examine how legitimization strategies are constructed, the methodology is considered to combine appropriate and supplementary tools to analyze political discourse and address the main research question.

The study focuses on what Netanyahu conveys and does not examine how the message is received by audiences, nor the measurable effects on public opinion or international relations. While the study takes an interest in how context shapes discourse, the aim is not to prove a causal relationship – such as whether international criticism and public opinion directly affected Netanyahu's rhetoric – but rather to explore how such dynamics are reflected within the discourse.

5.3 Ethical considerations

In this study, the author strives to adhere to good research practice and maintain quality. While quantitative studies concern validity and reliability, qualitative studies address trustworthiness and credibility. In favor of these two perspectives, this thesis addresses reflexivity and positionality and presents a separate Excel file containing the coded legitimization strategies and interpretations. This is done to promote transparency and allow the reader to assess the interpretations and validate the study's conclusions (Cope, 2014:89-90).

In this study, the author incorporates reflexivity, a process where the researcher identifies how their own values, assumptions and biases might influence the research process (Pretorius, 2024:2711). Reflexivity is considered an important quality marker in interpretivist research, increasing transparency and trustworthiness (Schwartz-Shea & Yanow, 2012:101-104). The author of this study has no personal, ideological or political ties to either Israel or Palestine, and has not previously researched the conflict. However, as an observer of an ongoing humanitarian crisis, the author is not completely detached from emotional responses to human suffering and

sympathizes with the victims. During the period covered by this study, the conflict escalated and events occurring after the speeches may affect retrospective interpretation of the discourse. Moreover, public discourse, media coverage and social media surrounding the conflict may also affect interpretations. This means that the study will not claim to present an objective account of Netanyahu's discourse but rather reflects a single interpretation shaped by the author's own positionality and sociopolitical context. The author also acknowledges that, by focusing on a powerful actor and legitimization strategies in conflict, this thesis provides a platform for power that excludes input from other groups.

5.4 Material

The empirical material consists of fourteen speeches delivered by Benjamin Netanyahu between 2023 and 2025. As this thesis focuses on the escalation of the war in Gaza following the events of October 7, 2023, the temporal scope is limited to the period thereafter. The first speech included was delivered on October 12, 2023, and the most recent speech on October 13, 2025. Four speeches in 2023, four in 2024, and six in 2025 are included, and although the number of speeches varies across the years, the analysis focuses on the function and contextual role of legitimization strategies rather than their frequency. Of the fourteen speeches, seven were delivered after the ICC arrest warrant was issued on November 21, 2024, and three after the release of the COI genocide report on September 16, 2025.

The selected speeches are delivered in English, primarily because the study focuses on Netanyahu's communication directed toward an international audience rather than a domestic one. By speaking English, Netanyahu can target a broader global audience, providing them with access to his discourse and influencing their perceptions (AlKhuraibet, 2024:2). The material is further limited to video-recorded speeches accompanied by transcripts for coding. The speeches were delivered in a variety of physical and institutional settings, including the U.S. Congress, the Israeli Parliament, the United Nations and the foreign press. They were primarily observed to have been delivered in Israel or the United States. Although the characteristics of the speeches vary, the English language is what directs the speeches towards an international audience and can be considered a tactical choice to increase persuasion and strengthen the connection with the audience (Kawashima, 2021:93). For this reason, the language choice is considered a central criterion in the selection of material.

The material is collected from official Israeli government channels and other media outlets. To ensure credibility, the CRAAP test was applied throughout the data collection process to assess currency, relevance, authority, accuracy, and purpose (University of Chicago Library, 2025). In particular, the spoken content was cross-checked against the transcript to verify accuracy, and material was gathered from original and authoritative sources to minimize the risk of altered, misleading or manipulated data.

6. Analysis and discussion

This chapter applies a critical discourse analysis perspective in combination with the chosen analytical framework to examine Benjamin Netanyahu's speeches. The first section addresses the first operationalized question by identifying and analyzing legitimization strategies at the linguistic micro-level, using Reyes' framework. The selected quotations presented below most clearly represent each category. The second section addresses the second operationalized question by examining whether and how these strategies evolve over time and in relation to the broader political and international context, drawing on van Dijk's socio-cognitive theory of context at the macro-level. Together, the analysis links micro-level linguistic strategies to macro-level political objectives through the strategic function of legitimization, thereby finally answering the research question.

6.1 What legitimization strategies does Netanyahu employ in his speeches to justify the war in Gaza?

6.1.1 Emotions

This section identifies instances when Netanyahu is perceived to employ linguistic choices that evoke feelings of anger, fear and sadness. These emotions are frequently constructed through discursive patterns of moral polarization such as "us vs. them", "good vs. evil" and "positive self-representation vs. negative other-representation". Anger is mobilized through depictions of Hamas as brutal and inhumane, fear through representation of the group as an ongoing existential threat and sadness through references to loss, grief and victimhood. These emotional constructions constitute the most prominent form of legitimization in Netanyahu's discourse, as demonstrated below.

"*They savagely murdered 1,200 people. They raped and mutilated women. They beheaded men. They burned babies alive. They burned entire families alive—babies, children, parents, grandparents. It seems reminiscent of the Nazi Holocaust*." (Speech 7, 2024)

The repeated use of the pronoun "they" establishes Hamas as a clear aggressor and immoral out-group. The graphic verbs and references to civilians, particularly babies and children

representing innocence, mobilize anger and moral outrage, while the Holocaust comparison situates the violence within a broader narrative of Jewish collective suffering, further intensifying anger.

"*These savage murderers, our enemies, seek not only to destroy us, but they seek to destroy our common civilization and return all of us to a dark age of tyranny and terror*." (Speech 7, 2024)

Through expressions such as "seek to destroy" and "our enemies" Netanyahu extends the threat beyond Israel and positions Hamas as barbaric and existentially dangerous to shared values and the global order. By warning of a return to the "dark age of tyranny and terror" Netanyahu mobilizes fear by presenting inaction as a risk to security and freedom of the framed in-group.

"*A day earlier, I spoke to several of the families of these murdered hostages. It tears your heart out. I said to them that I'm sorry. I apologized that we, we didn't get them out. We worked so hard to get them. We were close. But we didn't. And they changed the torment of families worried about their loved ones to families grieving for their fallen beloved. That sentiment I know because I belong to that family.*" (Speech 6, 2024)

By recounting personal encounters with grieving families and aligning himself with their sorrow, Netanyahu frames the war as a shared obligation rather than a political choice. Grief is mobilized not as a reason for restraint, but a justification for continued military action to prevent further casualties.

Emotional appeals are further reinforced through a recurring moral polarization in which Israel and its allies are positioned as a moral in-group, while Hamas is constructed as an immoral out-group. This is constructed through "us vs. them", "good vs. evil" and "positive self-representation vs. negative other-representation", as demonstrated when Netanyahu states:

"*While Israel is doing everything to get Palestinian civilians out of harm's way, Hamas is doing everything to keep the Palestinian civilians in harm's way*." (Speech 4, 2023)

"*This is not a clash of civilizations. It's a clash between barbarism and civilization. It's a clash between those who glorify death and those who sanctify life*." (Speech 5, 2024)

"*So, there's a glee, a horrible glee, of death in the worship of a death cult there, that is completely the opposite of the values that we hold dear, life, liberty*." (Speech 11, 2025)

Through these representations, Israel is portrayed as actively protecting civilians, while Hamas is depicted as deliberately endangering them. Civilian harm is thus framed as the result of Hamas' actions rather than Israeli military action, redirecting blame towards the out-group and reinforcing emotions of anger. By framing the conflict as a struggle between "civilization" and "barbarism" and by aligning Israel with universal values such as life and liberty, Israeli military actions are constructed not only as legitimate self-defense but as a moral obligation in defense of shared human values. The repeated use of dehumanizing descriptions positions Hamas as an irrational and immoral actor. Through this moral polarization, responsibility for violence is placed on Hamas, while Israeli military actions are framed as ethically justified and necessary.

6.1.2 Hypothetical future

This section analyzes Netanyahu's use of hypothetical futures to justify courses of action by framing future scenarios as inevitable unless specific actions are taken. In Netanyahu's speeches, hypothetical future is primarily used to construct scenarios in which inaction or restraint would lead to negative consequences. These arguments frame military actions not as a choice, but as a necessity to prevent said future.

"*But we cannot give up the fight because, then I think, this will have disastrous consequences not only for the future of my country but for the future of your country, your countries*." (Speech 4, 2023)

"*If we leave Rafah, if we leave the Philadelphi Corridor, there won't be any pressure. We won't get the hostages*.**"** (Speech 6, 2024)

"*The final remnants of Hamas are holed up in Gaza City. They vow to repeat the atrocities of October 7th again and again and again, no matter how diminished their forces. That is why Israel must finish the job, and that is why we want to do so as fast as possible*." (Speech 12, 2025)

Together, these examples demonstrate how Netanyahu employs hypothetical future strategies to construct the continuation of Israeli military operations as necessary and justified. The future scenarios are framed as inevitable unless Israel acts in accordance with the specific course of action he suggests. By linking past atrocities to future inevitability, Netanyahu legitimizes Israeli military action as the sole viable option to prevent them. References to the October 7 attacks are repeatedly invoked as evidence of what will happen again if Israel fails to act. The decision-making is framed as urgent and unavoidable, where alternative courses of action are excluded.

6.1.3 Rationality

Rationality in Netanyahu's speeches is expressed through appeals to collective assessment, strategic reasoning, actions that "make sense" given the circumstances and what is presented as "the right thing" to do. Suggested courses of action are presented as the only effective and logical responses to threats, grounded in historical examples, strategy and necessity. By emphasizing careful deliberation and the necessity of these choices, rationality serves to legitimize Israel's actions as reasonable and justified, rather than impulsive and erratic.

"*And just as the civilized world united to defeat the Nazis and united to defeat ISIS, the civilized world must unite to defeat Hamas*." (Speech 3, 2023)

"*But our common assessment of all of the -- not only the cabinet members but also all the security forces and the military is that the ground action actually creates the possibility, not the certainty, but the possibility of getting our hostages out*." (Speech 4, 2023)

"*In response to this barbaric attack on October 7th, Israel did what it had to do. With indomitable courage, we set out to defend our people, to defeat our enemies, and to release our hostages*." (Speech 14, 2025)

These examples illustrate how Netanyahu employs rationality to legitimize the war by framing military action as logical and essential. By situating Israel within a broader historical context and comparing Hamas to the Nazis and ISIS, Netanyahu invokes past experiences in which the "civilized world" acted collectively against perceived threats, suggesting that similar action now is not only reasonable but expected. Rationality is further constructed through references

to collective assessments with cabinet members and military personnel, presenting them as carefully considered. Finally, by referring to the October 7 attack, Netanyahu presents Israeli military action as a rational response, necessitated by an external actor and the legal obligation to protect its citizens and territory.

6.1.4 Voices of expertise

Voices of expertise are employed by Netanyahu to legitimize the war by grounding them in external authority that supports his arguments. This is observed in Netanyahu's speech by referencing institutional authority such as the U.N, political leaders and military personnel. This author has strictly adhered to Reyes' criteria of what experts say or state, although the author believes that even references to support and the provision of a platform to speak in the U.S. already provide authoritative weight.

"*President Biden was absolutely correct in calling this 'sheer evil'*." (Speech 1, 2023)

"*John Spencer is head of urban warfare studies at West Point. Israel, he said, has implemented more precautions to prevent civilian harm than any military in history and beyond what international law requires*." (Speech 5, 2024)

"*This past June, when Israel struck Iran's nuclear facilities, German Chancellor Merz admitted the truth. He said, 'Israel is doing the dirty work for all of us'*." (Speech 12, 2025)

These excerpts illustrate how Netanyahu reinforces the legitimacy of the war and Israeli actions by invoking additional authority. By citing U.S. President Biden's description of Hamas as "sheer evil", Netanyahu aligns his framing of the conflict with a leading international ally, strengthening its moral legitimacy. To address criticism concerning civilian suffering in Gaza, Netanyahu references U.S. Colonel John Spencer to present Israeli precautions as exceeding legal requirements, framing Israeli warfare as both proportionate and compliant with international law. In reference to Chancellor Merz, Netanyahu further distributes responsibility for confronting shared threats, portraying Israeli actions not as unilateral aggression, but as a reluctant yet necessary task that other states avoid, yet benefit from.

6.1.5 Altruism

Through altruism, Netanyahu legitimizes the war as morally justified when undertaken to protect others. Rather than presenting the war as driven by national and personal self-interest, he portrays it as a responsibility to defend civilians, shared values and international security.

"*...it's not only to prevent them from terrorizing us, attacking us, it's also to prevent Hamas or any other terrorist organization from terrorizing the people of Gaza*." (Speech 6, 2024)

"*Ladies and gentlemen, we're committed to removing the curse of terrorism that threatens all civilized societies*." (Speech 7, 2024)

"*We pushed those two great perils away from our door, and away from your door, because Iran's plan was to have ballistic missiles that would reach first deep into Europe, then 8,000 kilometers*." (Speech 11, 2025)

These quotes illustrate how Netanyahu constructs legitimization as serving a greater good rather than being driven by self-interest. By asserting that Israel's actions aim to prevent terrorism against both Israelis and Palestinians, responsibility for civilian suffering is shifted towards Hamas, while Israeli military presence is framed as protective rather than aggressive. By further emphasizing that Israeli actions remove threats that endanger other states and safeguard "civilized societies", Netanyahu expands the scope of the war and presents Israel as confronting a shared threat on behalf of the international community.

6.2 Do these strategies remain consistent or vary over time, and how can any observed variation be interpreted in relation to the political and international context?

Building on the micro-level analysis in section 6.1, this section examines whether Benjamin Netanyahu's legitimization strategies remain consistent or vary between 2023 and 2025. It examines potential adaptations in the use and function of these strategies over time, before interpreting how such adaptations may relate to the political and international context. The analysis is guided by van Dijk's theory of context, which emphasizes that discourse is shaped by the speaker's subjective interpretations of what is relevant and appropriate in a given communicative situation (van Dijk, 2008;2009).

Strategy	2023	2024	2025	Total
Emotions	28	43	48	119
Hypothetical Future	6	21	23	50
Rationality	5	20	30	55
Voices of expertise	4	9	8	21
Altruism	5	14	14	33
Total	**48**	**107**	**123**	**278**

Table 1. Distribution of legitimization strategies in Netanyahu's speeches

An analysis of Netanyahu's speeches between 2023 and 2025 reveals both continuity and variation in his use of legitimization strategies. While all five strategies by Reyes are present throughout the material, the analysis reveals shifts in emphasis and function as the conflict progresses and international criticism intensifies.

In 2023, legitimization is predominantly achieved through emotional appeals, with limited reliance on hypothetical futures, rationality, expertise or altruism. In contrast, the speeches delivered in 2024 and 2025 show an increase in the use of the remaining four strategies. The expansion and incorporation of these strategies may indicate a greater need to supplement emotional appeals with more factual and robust forms of justification to construct legitimacy. The legitimization process appears to be becoming more complex and extensive, indicating a potential shift from assumed legitimacy to the need to actively defend it.

The analysis suggests that Netanyahu's legitimization strategies are not static but recalibrated over time in response to changing communicative demands and constraints. This reflects the concept of iterative discourse, in which political actors continually revise their arguments in response to public opinion and international censure to maintain support and mitigate criticism, particularly when earlier justifications are challenged or insufficient (Alexandrescu, 2025:).

6.2.1 Shifts in legitimization strategies

Although all five legitimization strategies occur across the analyzed speeches, their discursive function is perceived to change over time.

Emotional appeals:

In 2023, emotional appeals appear to primarily function to mobilize moral outrage and justify immediate military action. Graphic descriptions of violence, references to collective trauma such as the Holocaust, and portrayals of Hamas as an existential threat dominate the discourse. These appeals seem to simplify the morality of the war, positioning Israel as an innocent victim and framing military action as necessary and unquestionable. In 2024, emotional appeals are perceived to begin serving an additional defensive function. While emotions continue to mobilize support, they are increasingly invoked in response to emerging international criticism. Narratives of Israeli suffering and moral righteousness are employed to challenge accusations of civilian harm and disproportionate use of force, framing criticism as unfair and selective. By 2025, emotions are perceived as intensified to defend legitimacy. Moral polarization is emphasized through "good vs. evil" and "us vs. them" framing, and emotions are increasingly observed to delegitimize Israel's critics explicitly. The now formal accusations against Israel are rejected and countered with victimhood and virtue, shifting the responsibility of civilian casualties onto Hamas, while portraying Israel as morally superior not only to its adversaries but also to its critics, such as the ICC and the UN member states.

Rationality:

In 2023, rationality is primarily observed by citing how the "civilized world" has acted in previous conflicts, thereby justifying similar actions in the present. From 2024 onward, rationality is perceived to become more prominent and systematic. Netanyahu increasingly relies on strategic assessments, numerical data and result-based arguments to counter ICC allegations. This is demonstrated by references to aid deliveries, evacuation warnings, the presentation of war goals, Israel's self-defense and the successful outcomes achieved through actions taken. In 2025, rational reasoning is further employed to reject the UN genocide report and frame Israeli actions as proportionate and consistent with international laws. Rationality is thus perceived to function not only to justify military conduct but also to challenge the credibility of the accusing institutions.

Voices of expertise:

In 2023, voices of expertise are observed as mainly employed to reinforce moral polarization, comparing Hamas to ISIS and the Nazis. In 2024, external authorities are increasingly cited to counter accusations of disproportionality and support Israel's military conduct. By 2025, Netanyahu references military experts and political leaders more directly in relation to the ICC arrest warrant and genocide report. The strategy is perceived as delegitimizing the ICC and the UN. Over time, the growing reliance on external authority may suggest an awareness that domestic legitimacy is insufficient in the context of international legal and moral scrutiny, as voices of expertise serve to externalize legitimacy and distribute responsibility beyond Israel.

Altruism and hypothetical future:

In 2023, altruism and hypothetical futures primarily emphasize the threat to civilization and the consequences of inaction. In 2024, these strategies become more widely employed. Altruism is used to portray Israel's military actions as also protecting Palestinian civilians and shared universal values of peace. Netanyahu introduces Iran as a broader threat and expands the conflict by arguing that Israel's actions also protect American and Western interests. Hypothetical futures appear to construct inaction as leading to renewed violence or the repetition of October 7, framing continued military action as preventative rather than aggressive. By 2025, these strategies are perceived to become increasingly defensive. Military action is framed as serving the interests of allied states and "civilized societies" more broadly, with Israel portrayed as bearing the burden of a collective struggle, bringing in the UK and Australia. These strategies further expand the conflict beyond Israel's immediate security concerns and redistribute responsibility across the international community.

6.2.2 Interpretation of discourse

The observed adaptations in Netanyahu's legitimization strategies can be interpreted through van Dijk's theory of context, which emphasizes that discourse is shaped by the speaker's subjective interpretations of the communicative situation and of what is relevant, appropriate, and necessary given the evolving social and political environment (van Dijk, 2009).

Over the analyzed period, the speeches can be understood in three phases of the conflict, each associated with a different legitimacy status. In 2023, Netanyahu's discourse is embedded in a context model dominated by crisis and initial shock following the October 7 attacks. The perceived audience is mainly sympathetic, the communicative goal is perceived to be mobilization and legitimacy is largely implicit and uncontested. This may explain the dominance of emotional appeals and the limited rationality, expertise and altruism, and how it may reflect a situation in which extensive justification is not yet perceived as necessary.

In 2024, the context model appears to shift into a transitional phase. As the war continues and civilian suffering in Gaza becomes increasingly evident, Netanyahu's discourse reflects an awareness of increasing international criticism. The perceived audience expands to include legal institutions, critical allies and global public opinion. Even prior to the ICC arrest warrant, Netanyahu explicitly addresses allegations of deliberately targeting and starving civilians, indicating that these accusations have become noticeable contextual constraints. Within van Dijk's framework, this may suggest a shift in perceived participants and communicative goals, which help explain why legitimization strategies become more defensive and evidence-based. Legitimacy is no longer taken for granted but pre-emptively defended.

By 2025, Netanyahu's discourse is situated within a context model characterized by a legitimacy crisis. Following the ICC arrest warrant and the COI genocide report, legitimacy is no longer merely questioned but formally challenged. The communicative environment is highly contested and Netanyahu's discourse reflects an awareness that both Israel's actions and his own leadership are under international scrutiny. In this phase, legitimization strategies become more explicit and confrontational. Rationality and voices of expertise are not used only to justify Israeli actions, but also to challenge the legitimacy of the accusing institutions themselves.

A distinction between the discourse in 2024 and 2025 concerns the status of international criticism. In 2024, allegations against Israel are emerging from institutions, organizations and media outlets and although severe enough for Netanyahu to address, these claims remain contestable and informal. Netanyahu's discourse during this phase could be understood as pre-emptive, aimed at countering allegations before they solidify. By contrast, in 2025, the discourse unfolds in the aftermath of the ICC arrest warrant issued in November 2024 and the COI genocide report issued in September 2025. At this stage, criticism is no longer speculative

or politically motivated but grounded in formal legal decisions. This shift marks a transition from contested legitimacy to a legitimacy crisis, altering the conditions under which legitimacy is constructed.

Seen through van Dijk's framework, these developments suggest that Netanyahu's legitimization strategies evolve as his interpretation of the communicative situation changes. As audiences, constraints and expectations shift across the phases, so do the forms of legitimization that are perceived as most appropriate and relevant. The discourse can be argued to adapt to what is interpreted as necessary to maintain legitimacy at different stages of the war. van Dijk's framework allows for an understanding of how these adaptations emerge from Netanyahu's subjective assessment of relevance and appropriateness, offering a nuanced explanation of why legitimization strategies intensify, diversify and shift in function between 2023 and 2025.

6.3 Discussion

This thesis examined how legitimacy was constructed and defended in Benjamin Netanyahu's political discourse between 2023 and 2025, in relation to international criticism. The findings suggest that Netanyahu's legitimization strategies are not static but evolve in relation to shifting political and international circumstances. While emotional appeals dominate the early phase of the conflict in 2023, the discourse becomes increasingly complex in 2024 and 2025, demonstrating a greater reliance on more robust strategies like hypothetical futures, rationality, voices of expertise and altruism. Netanyahu is observed to recalibrate the function of these strategies, indicating a shift from assumed legitimacy to the need to defend it. This suggests that, in accordance with Alexandrescu (2025), political actors continually revise their arguments in response to public and international scrutiny to maintain support and mitigate criticism when earlier justifications are challenged or deemed insufficient.

In 2023, the discourse is characterized by moral polarization, victimhood narratives and emotionally charged representations of Hamas as an existential threat. In this phase, legitimacy appears uncontested and justification functions primarily to mobilize support in favor of military action. As the war continues and international criticism intensifies, particularly in relation to civilian suffering, the discourse appears to shift. In 2024 and 2025, Netanyahu increasingly responds to accusations of disproportionality, violations of international law and genocide. The strategies are perceived as more defensive, with a greater emphasis on rational

argumentation, external authority and altruistic framing. This development suggests an awareness that emotional appeals alone are inadequate to maintain legitimacy in the communicative environment, reflecting changing communicative demands.

Interpreted through van Dijk's socio-cognitive theory of context, these shifts reflect Netanyahu's potential change in perception of the communicative situation. As the perceived audience shifts from sympathetic allies to condemning international and legal actors, the discourse is perceived as adapting accordingly. What is considered relevant and appropriate shifts from mobilization and persuasion to defense and delegitimization. This supports van Dijk's previous work, which characterizes legitimization discourse as a form of strategic crisis management aimed at preserving authority (van Dijk, 1998:255-257).

These findings both confirm and extend previous research on Netanyahu's political discourse. Earlier studies identify emotional strategies such as moral polarization, positive self- and negative other-representation, victimhood, and denial of responsibility (Algurjia et al., 2024), as well as the us vs. them dichotomy and Israel's alignment with universal values and norms (Alsemeiri et al., 2024). While existing research often analyzes individual speeches in isolation, this study's approach reveals how legitimization strategies are recalibrated in response to shifting international contexts, supporting Alexandrescu's (2025) argument that legitimization is dynamic. By demonstrating how legitimacy discourse adapts to account for different communicative situations and contexts, the thesis contributes to debates on legitimacy and wartime discourse within War Studies.

Moreover, this study contributes to War Studies by demonstrating how wartime legitimacy is actively constructed and defended through political discourse over time. By analyzing how legitimization strategies are recalibrated in relation to growing criticism, the study highlights the role of discourse as a key mechanism through which political leaders seek to maintain support for military action and political authority during armed conflicts. From a theoretical perspective, this study contributes to research on the legitimization of warfare by examining the interplay between discourse, conflict and society. Methodologically, the study shows the value of applying critical discourse analysis to analyze legitimization discourse and the approach can be applied to other cases in which political actors face international criticism during armed conflicts.

Several limitations should be acknowledged. First, the analysis relies on the author's interpretation of Netanyahu's speeches, which entails subjectivity inherent to qualitative research. While a systematic framework guides the analysis, alternative interpretations of the same material are possible. Second, the analysis focuses solely on Reyes' five legitimization strategies and does not account for other possible forms of legitimization that might be present in the speeches. These remain unexplored, thus potentially affecting the overall interpretation of Netanyahu's discourse. Third, the analysis centers on a single political actor's speeches within a timeframe, which limits generalizability. Finally, the study cannot isolate other variables that potentially have affected the recalibration of the legitimization strategies.

Some of these limitations could be addressed and explored in future research. Future recommendations to build on this analysis could be performed by incorporating additional legitimization strategies beyond those identified by Reyes, comparing Hebrew and English speeches or by comparing Netanyahu's speeches with another political leader facing international criticism. Such approaches could further highlight and expand how legitimacy is constructed across different audiences, situations and political actors.

7. Conclusion

The aim of this thesis was to examine how legitimacy is constructed and defended through political discourse over time in relation to international criticism during an armed conflict. Focusing on Benjamin Netanyahu's speeches from 2023 to 2025, the study analyzed how legitimization strategies were employed to justify the war in Gaza and how these strategies related to the surrounding political and international contexts.

The study set out to answer the research question "How is legitimacy constructed and defended in Benjamin Netanyahu's political discourse between 2023 and 202 in relation to international criticism during the war in Gaza?" The analysis supports the idea that legitimization discourse is not static but evolves as the conflict progresses and criticism intensifies. In the early phase of the war, legitimacy appears largely assumed, with emotional appeals and moral polarization dominating the discourse to mobilize support and justify immediate military action. As the war escalates and international criticism increases, particularly in relation to civilian suffering and legal accountability, legitimization becomes more explicit and defensive. Netanyahu increasingly supplements emotional appeals with hypothetical futures, rational arguments, expert authority and altruistic framing, indicating a shift from mobilizing legitimacy to actively defending it.

These findings highlight the relationship between political discourse and its contextual environment, illustrating how political actors may adapt the emphasis and function of their legitimization strategies in response to perceived contextual pressures and constraints to maintain legitimacy and political authority. By conceptualizing legitimacy as a dynamic, context-dependent process, the study shows how political communication functions as a strategic tool for managing criticism and sustaining military operations. The results emphasize the importance of examining legitimization over time to better understand how contemporary armed conflicts are justified in response to legal and moral challenges.

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